

God is Breath Training Program - Course 1

Breath, Concentration, and the God Ideal

Lesson 3 Practices and Assignments

(by Murshid Wali Ali, with some updates by Sheikh Muiz)

Beloved Ones of God,

Peace and great success be with you, as we continue to move with our caravan down this path, in harmony with each other and with the current of the Breath. May we be graced to remember to remember to focus our awareness with heart-full interest, resting lightly in the swing of the breath and very gently exerting our will to bring the breath into its optimum condition through all the teachings we have received and have been practicing.

In the midst of everything we do let's be at ease and feel the beauty at the heart of our process. Continuing to maintain a daily rhythm of concentration will be highly beneficial for us all.

Below are the basic practices that have been assigned for Lesson 3. Some changes have been made in the previous practices given, and there are some new assignments and options. In general, formal practice sessions should be approximately the same length as before, while informal opportunities are endless.

Love and Blessings,
Wali Ali, 2013

Some specific daily practices to take on for Lesson 3:

1) Sufi Invocation – 3 times

Begin with recitation of the Sufi Invocation three times, followed by inner reflection in which you connect with the meaning of this prayer. Then clearly find and establish your own intention and your own authentic prayer ... for this practice session, for your life, for whatever may arise.

2) Ya Raqib – 33 times vocally, then several times on the breath (Fikr), then a few more breaths just feeling the essence of it without the mental recitation (Fikr as-Sirr)

Remember to consciously and gently call forth heart-centered attention and interest in what you are focused upon in your awareness.

3) Daily Sitting Meditation – 15 minutes

Stage 1: Begin by becoming aware of your breath wherever it is at this moment. Allow yourself to breathe naturally. Notice the rhythm of this breath and consciously maintain this rhythm. Gradually allow and encourage the breath to become longer and more refined. Become aware of the small natural pause at the top and bottom of the breath.

Stage 2: Resting awareness in the center of feeling in the heart, place your attention on the magnetism (prana) that is carried by the breath. You are drawing from the all-pervading life in space. Consciously bring the magnetism into the heart (middle of the chest) as you inhale and

radiate it as you exhale. Your whole physical body becomes charged with life-essence and power.

Stage 3: Retaining your focus in the heart, call forth all this feeling as love. Using the rhythm that has been established in your breath, stay attentive to this regular swing — long, refined, rhythmical.

If the breath begins to stray from this state gently bring it back. Begin to slowly intone the sound "Allah, Allah" in thought and feeling matching the rhythm of the breath. Let remembrance of the perfect One naturally fill the length and breadth of the breath. Constantly flow with the awareness of the joy of the essence of your life in Allah, and be alive to love's longing for completion in that Oneness.

4) Descent of the Dove Concentration – 5 minutes, on ALTERNATE DAYS

This practice is to be done on alternate days with reciting Surah Ikhlas and the concentration on Ya 'Ahad, Ya Samad described in #5.

Concentrate for five minutes on the Dove as the descent of the Spirit of Guidance, the Divine Breath, as described here and in the reading selection for Lesson 3 – Murshid SAM's Commentary on Gatha Series 1, Naqshibandi (Symbology) Number 5: The Symbol of the Dove, PDF page 3, top.

[NOTE: In the reading selection, the passages marked GATHA are the words of Hazrat Inayat Khan, and those marked TASAWWUF (sometimes incorrectly spelled "tassawuf") are Murshid SAM's commentaries on the GATHA passages, and RYAZAT (also spelled Riyazat or even Riyadhat is Arabic and Urdu for exercise or practice, and is used in this context to indicate a spiritual practice. In conversational Arabic it means sports)

Tasawwuf is the Arabic term for the process of realizing ethical and spiritual ideals, and is often translated in English as "Sufism", or "becoming a Sufi", and by extension mystical, or esoteric teachings or explanations. Murshid SAM used it throughout his numerous Commentaries on Hazrat Inayat Khan's teachings. — Muiz]

Inhale hearing the sound "Huuuuu" and receiving the breath through the crown center while at the same time visualizing the descent of the dove, the Holy Spirit, the Spirit of Guidance.

Allow this to flow into the heart.

Then exhale "Allah" through the heart — expressing living magnetism, love, generous well-being, beneficial intention. Authentically express the stream of your offering through the heart.

5) Recitation of Surah Ikhlas – 1 time, followed by a Breath Contemplation using Ya 'Ahad Ya Samad – 5 minutes, ON ALTERNATE DAYS

This practice is to be done on alternate days with the Descent of the Dove Concentration described in #4

Follow the recitation of Surah Ikhlas with the breathing contemplation practice using Ya 'Ahad and Ya Samad.

Surah al-Ikhlâs – The Sincerity

Bismillah ir-Rahman ir-Rahim

(We begin) in the Name of Allah, Everlasting Mercy, Infinite Compassion.

Qul huwa Allahu 'Ahad

Say, Hu is Allah, The One

Allahu us-Samad

Allah, The Eternal, Absolute

Lam yalid, wa lam yulad

Hu never gave birth, and Hu never was born

wa lam yaku llahu kufuwan 'Ahad

And there is none comparable to The One.

When you exhale, mentally and in feeling repeat "Ya Samad", continually dissolving into the Oneness that is unending. Breathing out "Ya Samad" is the same as breathing out "Toward the One" and "becoming melting snow", dissolving the sense of your small self into the eternal, continuous and unending, All-Pervading Oneness.

When you inhale, mentally and in feeling repeat "Ya 'Ahad.". There is nothing outside of the Unity of the One that is al-'Ahad. Experience this Unity as a dot, and with the inhalation of Ya 'Ahad draw the reality of All That Is into a dot and experience integration of self in this dot. You become aware of the One that is the ultimate Unity of Being. Nothing is outside of this One. Nothing can be added to it or subtracted from it.

To be fully conscious as you perform this practice asks you to accept that what you call your own awareness is actually an activity of the Only Being, and is nothing but that Being.

This practice is highly recommended because oscillating back and forth between the dot and the continuation of the infinite and eternal circumference of the expanding circle gives the right psychological framework for progress in meditation. It allows us to ease into the letting go of self, of "dying before death".

The Sufi Invocation uses all these levels of meaning of the One.

6) Qasab (Alternate Nostril) Breathing Practice – 5 cycles

(Qasab is similar to the Yogic Nadi Shodhana Pranayama breathing practice, but without the retention of the breath after the exhalation, and possibly starting with a different nostril. Your mentor can demonstrate one way of holding the hand(s) and fingers, for closing and opening the different nostrils.)

The breathing in Qasab is not as refined and delicate as during the other breath practices and contemplations we've been doing so far. It is deep and full and smooth and even, for both inhalations and exhalations, but without being heavy or coarse or strained.

The nostril not being breathed through is gently held closed with a thumb or finger, and both are gently held closed during the retentions.

The pattern for the timing of the exhalations, inhalations, and retentions, in the way we'll be doing Qasab, is 8 counts or beats for both exhalations and inhalations, and 16 counts for the retentions. So the pattern is like this: 8 – 8 – 16.

To assist with maintaining consistent timings, and to focus on the healing qualities that are present in the Breath, plus that Allah-God-Goddess-Oneness is the source of all healing, we'll mentally repeat in thought and feeling "Allah Shafee Allah Kafee" (*Allah is The Healer, Allah is Sufficient for Every Need*) during all three stages.

Al-lah Sha-fee, Al-lah Ka-fee – 8 syllables for the exhalations,
and

Al-lah Sha-fee, Al-lah Ka-fee – 8 for the inhalations,
and

Al-lah Sha-fee, Al-lah Ka-fee, Al-lah Sha-fee, Al-lah Ka-fee – 16 syllables for the retentions.

To begin:

Close the left nostril, and exhale through the right for 8 syllables

Immediately close the right and open the left, and inhale through the left for 8 syllables

Close both nostrils and hold for 16 syllables

Open the left and exhale through the left for 8 syllables

Immediately close the left and open the right, and inhale through the right for 8 syllables

Close both nostrils and hold for 16

This is 1 cycle, and we'll do 5 cycles daily.

To finish:

At the conclusion of the practice, take a few minutes to be fully aware of your breath in both nostrils. Throughout the practice we are connecting in our breath and in our prayer with God's all sufficient power of healing and purification.

Stay still for a bit, and in the manner of ar-Raqib, notice with gentle, loving interest and curiosity, how you feel, what your body, your breath, your energy field, your heart is feeling like.

If you've never done this practice before:

If you've never done Qasab, or Yoga Pranayama breathing before, be sure to let your mentor know (and your Sufi Guide if you are working with one), so you can discuss how best to modify Qasab, if necessary. so that you move into it gently. Perhaps they'll recommend doing only 3 cycles, or only retaining the breath for a few seconds while noticing the pause, for a month or two, before increasing the cycles, or length of the retention.

In any case, please stay in touch with your mentor (and Guide) and let them know if you're becoming spaced out in other areas of your everyday life, or if too much inner material is arising for you to deal with productively.

In addition to balancing the the Breath in the right, left, and central breath channels (in yoga terminology, the Principal Nadis) the retention of the breath for twice the length of exhalations and inhalations in Qasab (or Nadi Shodhana) also works to clear out and purify both the principle channels themselves as well as all of the other nadis, so that they begin to move more prana through them, which energizes the whole system, bringing more magnetism, more vitality, and more light.

This additional energy brings great benefits to body, mind and heart, and may also stir up greater awareness and feeling of old wounds or traumas, and other things that may have been buried or ignored for a long time, in order to help deal with them. While this is a part of the purification process, we don't want life to be in upheaval, so if it does begin happening, let your mentor (and Guide) know straight away.

Very importantly: There must be no straining, no tension, no "bearing down", while holding the inhalation, and no "toughing it out" waiting to exhale. The moment you begin to feel like you need to exhale you should exhale. If you retain the inhalation beyond this point, strain will enter into the practice, and the exhalation is likely to be more pushed than slow and even, and the next inhalation more of a gasp, than even and smooth. This would be counter-productive

TIP: If you haven't reached the end of the 16 syllables during the retention and you're feeling like you have to exhale, you've been mentally reciting the syllables too slowly for your retention capacity at this point. Try again reciting a bit more quickly overall rather than straining, or stopping short of the full 16 syllables for the retention, or reciting the 16 more quickly.

The tempo through all 3 stages should remain steady and even, no matter how slowly or quickly you recite the syllables — 8, 8, 16. To use a musical metaphor, if each syllable were to be sung, each syllable would need to be sung for the same length, all half notes, all quarter notes, all eighth notes, etc.

7) 20 Purification Breaths and Healing Prayer

There are many different forms in which this practice is done. In this class we are placing our attention throughout the breaths, on the 3 avenues of purification mentioned in the prayer Nayaz.

Finish the Healing Breaths with Nayaz, the Healing Prayer, again opening to the 3 powers.

The Purification Breaths:

Each breath is slow, gentle, and refined, inhalations and exhalations the same length. Each of the breathing patterns is repeated 5 times, mentally and in feeling repeating "Ya Shafee" (O Healer) during the inhalations, and "Ya Kafee" (O Remedy, Sufficient for every need) during the exhalations.

1st pattern: IN the NOSE, and OUT the NOSE.

2nd pattern: IN the NOSE, and OUT the MOUTH.

3rd pattern: IN in the MOUTH, and OUT the NOSE.

4th pattern: IN the MOUTH, and OUT the MOUTH.

The Healing Prayer, Nayaz:

“Beloved Lord, almighty God, through the rays of the Sun, through the waves of the air, through Thy All-Pervading Life in Space, purify and revivify me, and I pray, heal my body, heart, and soul.”

8) Shiva's 112 Centering Breath Meditations – Choose 1 of these every day, do it for 5 minutes

(These 112 meditations are excerpted from the Vijnana Bhairava, Sochanda, and Malini Vijaya Tantras, and were included by Paul Reps at the end of his book "Zen Flesh, Zen Bones". A much more poetic, body-centered and sensuous, and tantric English rendering of these 112, and more, from the Vijnana Bhairava Tantra are available as "The Radiance Sutras", section 2. The Yukti Verses, by Lorin Roche.

A comparison of these 2 renderings of the same Sanskrit verses is included after the assignments.)

#3. Whenever inbreath and outbreath fuse, at this instant touch the energy-less, energy-filled CENTER.

#23. Feel your substance, bones, flesh, blood, saturated with Cosmic Essence.

#4. When breath is all out (up) and stopped of itself, or all in (down) and stopped — in such universal pause, one's small self vanishes.

#31. With intangible breath in center of forehead, as this reaches heart at the moment of sleep, have direction over dreams and over death itself.

#56. ... As breath comes silently in, feel the sound H-H-H-H.

To be done at any time:

9) Toward the One Walking Practice – at least once a week

Do the following walking practice in nature if possible when you can.

Breathing “Toward the One” in and out from the heart center. Opening, encouraging, and allowing your heart to feel lovingly drawn by the beauty of the Perfect One, and feeling the inner harmony of your connection with the Source and Goal of all, you radiate the light-ray of your intention along the path of your life.

At the same time, feel your heart drawn to the Source by its magnetism, beauty, and perfection. Be aware of both poles of this practice simultaneously — your heart and the Source, calling to each other, drawing each other together.

10) Attention to Breath – Periodically throughout the day

Check in with your breath throughout the day and notice its condition. For example, it could be Jelal, Jemal, Kemal, Urooj, Zaval, refined/coarse, powerful/dull, broad/narrow, etc.

After checking in, consciously confirm the rhythm in your breath or, when needed, establish a

rhythm in your breath. Stay with this awareness of the swing of your breath and allow it to gradually become longer and more refined.

Then continue with your activities. Notice any way in which your emotions have been influenced by having done the practice mentioned above.

11) Journaling – At least once a week

Continue to write in your journal at least once a week or more. In addition to noting the condition of your breath at different times, and what you learned from it, also give some attention in your journal to the different things that your breath connects with and what it draws from that connection.

Radiance Sutras compared with Paul Reps' 112 Centering Breath Meditations

(112 Breath Meditations #3)

*Whenever inbreath and outbreath fuse,
at this instant touch the energy-less, energy-filled CENTER.)*

#3 (Yukti Verse 26)

Enter these turning points,
Where the rhythms of life transform Into each other.

Breath flows in, filling, filling,
In this moment, drink eternity.

Breath flows out, emptying, emptying,
Offering itself to infinity.
Cherishing these moments,
Mind dissolves into heart,
Heart dissolves into space,
Body becomes a vibrating field,
Pulsating between fullness and emptiness.

(112 Breath Meditations #23)

*Feel your substance, bones, flesh, blood,
saturated with Cosmic Essence.)*

#24 (Yukti Verse 47)

Forget all of your ideas about the body—
It's this way or it's that way.

Just be with any area of it,
This present body,

As permeated with limitless space,
Drenched in freedom.

(112 Breath Meditations #4)

*When breath is all out (up) and stopped of itself,
or all in (down) and stopped —
in such universal pause, one's small self vanishes.*

#4 (Yukti Verse 27)

At the end of the exhale,
Breath surrenders to quietude.
For a moment you hang in the balance—
Suspended
In the fertile spaciousness
That is the source of breath.

At the end of the inhale,
Filled with the song of the breath,
There is a moment when you are simply
Holding the tender mystery.

In these interludes,
Experience opens into exquisite vastness
With no beginning and no end.
Embrace this infinity without reservation.
You are its vessel.

(112 Breath Meditations #31)

*With intangible breath in center of forehead,
as this reaches heart at the moment of sleep,
have direction over dreams and over death itself.*

#32 (Yukti Verse 55)

Strong or soft, wild or serene—
Wherever breath flows there is song.
Hear its whisper touching behind the face,
Singing in the throat,
Dancing spirals in the sanctuary of your heart.

In this practice of listening,
A moment may come when you just want to lie down.
This is a doorway—surrender.

Fall into the wide-open embrace of life.
You are the instrument breath is playing.

All the meditations you have ever loved
Are vibrating in this luxurious hum,
Continuing even in sleep and dreams.
This is your school. Just you and infinity.
The texture of the Self is untamed freedom.

(112 Breath Meditations #56)

... As breath comes silently in, feel the sound H-H-H-H.

#58 (Yukti Verse 81)

The tongue is made of truth and flame.
On it dance the triple fires of spirit, body, soul.

Trace this dance from the depths of your core,
Rising upward through the crown of your being.
Every offering of breath and food
Feeds this holy flame.

Touch the tip of the tongue
To the roof of the mouth, lightly.
Inquire into the luminosity above.

Breathe out with a quiet *h a a a a*.

You are an altar to the flame of life.
Throw yourself into the throbbing intensity.
Become this dance,
Absorbed in radiant splendor.